

CASE JM-19

The Broken Riddle

Timnah, Philistia · c. 1100 BC



A riddle only one man on earth could answer — and thirty men answered it, perfectly, an hour before the deadline. Nobody saw. Nobody was told. Somebody is lying.

PAPER EDITION · NO DEVICE REQUIRED

THE CHRONICLE SOCIETY

CASE JM-19

The Broken Riddle

Investigators:

Opened: Closed:

✂ cut out and stick on the front of your case folder

BEFORE THE LESSON — PREPARING THE PACK

Ten minutes with a pair of scissors and four envelopes, and this case runs with no screen at all.

1 Print the whole pack

Single sided is easiest for cutting. Card stock makes better evidence but ordinary paper is fine.

2 Remove the answer key

The last page is the teacher's answer key. Take it out before anything else, or the case is over before it starts.

3 Cut out the open evidence

The 7 cards marked **OPEN FILE** go loose into the case folder. These are what the team starts with.

4 Make up the sealed bundles

You need **eight envelopes**. Cut out the labels on the envelope-label sheet and stick one on each.

- Into the envelope labelled **7320**, put the 4 cards marked **BUNDLE B**.
- Into the envelope labelled **HEIFER**, put the 3 cards marked **BUNDLE C**.
- Into each of the other six envelopes, put one of the small "not this one" slips.

Every envelope should look the same from the outside. That is the whole point.

5 Set the desk

Put the folder, the eight envelopes, the elimination board sheet, the evidence tags, the accusation form and a case record sheet on the table. Give each team scissors, a pen and a glue stick.

Time: 60–100 minutes, or two lessons. **Teams of two or three.** Any more and somebody stops reading.

THE INVESTIGATOR'S MANUSCRIPT

Read this out, or hand it to the team and let them run themselves. Do not read ahead.

1 Open the folder and read everything

Spread the 7 documents across the desk so you can see them all at once. Read every one before you decide anything at all. Move them around. Put the ones that seem to belong together next to each other.

Do not skip this. Teams that skip it lose more time later than the reading would have cost.

2 Work out the first seal

Four questions. Each answer is a single digit, and each one is answerable from a different document you already have.

1. How many days was the wedding feast to last? _____
2. For how many days could the thirty not solve the riddle? _____
3. How many journeys did Samson make down to Timnah before the feast? _____
4. How many people had Samson told about the lion? _____

Write the four digits in order. That is your seal number.

3 Open the sealed bundle

Find the envelope with your seal number on it and open **that one only**. If the slip inside says you are wrong, go back and check each digit against its own document.

The other envelopes hold nothing but a note telling you to think again. Opening them all only spoils it for yourselves.

4 Read the new evidence

Add the 4 new documents to the desk. Read them the same way — all of them, before deciding anything.

5 Fill in the riddle sheet

Every answer on the riddle sheet is a word you can find in the documents on your desk. Six squares carry a small number: collect those letters in number order and you have the keyword.

6 Open the second bundle

Find the envelope with your keyword on it. Open that one only. Add the 3 documents to the desk.

7 Close the routes on the board

Lay out the elimination board sheet. Cut out the evidence tags. For each of the five explanations, place the **one** tag naming the document that destroys it — not evidence that argues against it, the single fact that makes it impossible.

When you are all agreed, glue them down.

8 File the conclusion

Fill in the accusation form. Choose one conclusion and write your reasoning, naming at least two pieces of evidence. Then complete the case record and hand it in.

9

Close the case

Your teacher will check the board and sign the certificate. Put the certificate, your case record and anything else you want to keep into your case folder.

THE OPEN FILE — CUT THESE OUT

These 7 documents go loose in the folder. The team starts with all of them.

BRIEFING

Letter from the Case Supervisor

The Chronicle Society · Department of Unsolved Antiquities

To the investigating team,

A wedding feast at Timnah, in Philistine country, in the days when Israel had no king. Seven days of eating and drinking, and thirty young Philistine men brought in to keep the bridegroom company — whether he wanted them or not.

On the first day the bridegroom, an Israelite named Samson, set them a riddle and staked a great deal of expensive cloth on it. **For three days they had nothing.** On the seventh day, with the light going, they gave him the answer — and they gave it perfectly.

That should not have been possible. The riddle was not a puzzle about the world. It was a puzzle about **one private thing that had happened to one man, with no one else there.** You cannot reason your way to it. You can only be told.

YOUR TASK

Work out **how the answer got out.** Five explanations have been offered. Test each against the file and throw out the ones it will not carry.

HOW THE FILE WORKS

- Read everything on the desk before you decide anything.
- The first locked bundle opens on a **four-digit code**, and every digit is answerable from the documents you already have.
- The second opens on a **keyword that is written nowhere in the file.** You will have to build it yourself, on the **Riddle Sheet** — the crossword in the top bar. Its answers all come from the evidence, and six numbered squares spell the word you need.
- Then take it to the **Pinboard** and eliminate.

A secret has no legs. If it moved, somebody carried it — and somebody had a reason to.

A. Thorne

Case Supervisor

Reconstructed from Judges 14, with background from Judges 13 and 15.

✂ cut here

The Riddle and the Wager

Set on the first day of the feast

The bridegroom put it to the thirty companions in front of the whole company, and the terms were agreed out loud, so that nobody could argue about them afterwards.

THE RIDDLE, WORD FOR WORD

*"Out of the eater, something to eat.
Out of the strong, something sweet."*

THE TERMS

TERM	AGREED
Time allowed	The seven days of the feast
If they answer it	Samson gives them thirty linen garments and thirty changes of clothes
If they cannot	They give him the same

That is a serious sum of cloth — the sort of stake that would empty a young man's household either way. Whoever lost this wager was going to feel it for years.

Note who is carrying the risk here: thirty of them, one of him. And they are on their own ground.

Background: Judges 14:12-14.

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Log of the Seven Days

Reconstructed from the accounts

DAY	WHAT IS RECORDED
1	The riddle is set. The thirty begin work on it.
2	Nothing.
3	Nothing. Three days gone and they cannot expound it.
4	The thirty go to Samson's wife — privately, away from him.
5	She begins to weep in front of Samson and press him for the answer.
6	She weeps. He does not tell her.
7	He tells her, because she pressed him hard. She goes to the thirty. Before the sun goes down, they give him the answer.

WHAT THE LOG SHOWS ABOUT THE SHAPE OF IT

Six days of open eating and drinking with the thirty produced **nothing at all**. Samson sat with these men, day after day, and the answer never came out of him.

Then, within hours of the weeping stopping, they had it — complete, exact, and delivered right on the deadline.

Ask the question a detective always asks about a timeline: what changed on the day it worked?

Background: Judges 14:14–18. Some manuscripts put the approach to the wife on the fourth day, others on the seventh; either way the pattern of the week is the same.

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STATEMENT

Statement — Samson of Zorah*The bridegroom, and the only man who knew*

"I went down to Timnah twice before the feast. The first time was to see the woman. **A young lion came roaring at me out of the vineyards**, off the road, and I killed it with nothing in my hands. There was no one with me. My father and mother were on the road, and they never saw it.

I did not tell them. I did not tell anybody. Not that day, not after.

The second journey was later, to fetch her. **I turned aside on my own to look at the carcass** — and there were bees in it, and honey. I scraped it out with my hands and ate as I walked. I gave some to my father and mother when I caught them up, and they ate it, and **I did not tell them where it came from either**.

So when they sat there on the seventh day and gave me my own riddle back, word for word, I knew exactly what had happened. There was one person on this earth I had told, and I had told her that morning.

That is what I said to them, in front of everybody: **if you had not ploughed with my heifer, you would not have found out my riddle.**"

Samson

Background: Judges 14:5–9, 14:18. "Ploughed with my heifer" is his own phrase — an accusation about whose animal did the work.

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STATEMENT

Statement — Samson's Father and Mother*Taken separately, at Zorah*

"We were on that road with him both times. We did not want the marriage and we said so, and he went anyway.

The first journey he left us for a while among the vineyards and came back to us and said nothing at all. We did not know a lion had come near him until long afterwards. **He never told us what he had done.**

The second time he handed us honey in his hands and we ate it, standing on the road. We asked where he had got it. **He would not say.** We assumed a hive in the rocks, because where else does honey come from?

So no — we could not have told those thirty men the answer. We did not have it ourselves. Whatever the riddle meant, we learned it the same evening they did, and we learned it from the shouting."

the father and mother of Samson

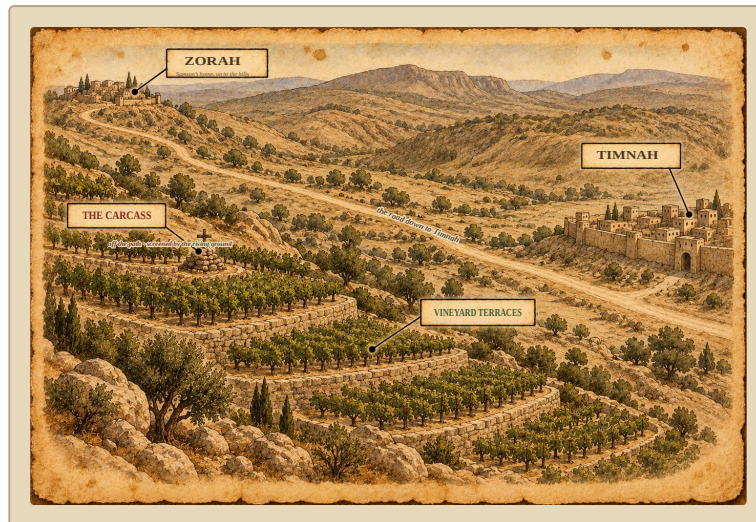
Background: Judges 14:6, 14:9 — "he did not tell them" is stated twice in the account, about both journeys.

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PLAN

The Road Down to Timnah

Where the lion was killed, and what could be seen



WHAT THE GROUND TELLS YOU

- The road from Zorah down to Timnah runs along open valley floor. The **vineyard terraces stand above it**, cut back into the slope.
- From the road you cannot see into the terraces. **From the terraces you can see anyone coming.** Samson would have known at once if he were being followed.
- The carcass lay **off the path**, in among the vines. It was not somewhere a traveller passes; it is somewhere you go on purpose.
- Both times, Samson left the road **alone** and rejoined his parents afterwards.

A witness would have had to leave the road, climb into a private vineyard, and watch a man kill a lion — and then say nothing about it for months.

Background: Judges 14:5–9.

✂ cut here

STATEMENT

Statement — One of the Thirty*Name withheld at his own request*

"We worked it out. That is what a riddle is for.

He set it on the first day and we sat with it. Thirty men, seven days, plenty of wine and nothing else to do. Eventually somebody says the right thing and everybody goes quiet. That is how it always happens.

No, I will not say which of us said it first. No, nobody paid anyone. No, we did not speak to his wife — and if she says otherwise she is a frightened girl who will say whatever is put in front of her.

You want to know why we cared so much about some cloth? Then you have never stood surety for thirty changes of clothes on the word of a man from the hills who thinks he is funny. **Ask what it would have cost each of us to lose.** Then ask what a man will do to get out of paying it."

DENIES ALL CONTACT WITH THE BRIDE

a companion of the feast

Background: Judges 14:11–18. The account records the thirty approaching the bride; this statement is the case file's reconstruction of their denial.

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ENVELOPE LABELS — CUT OUT AND STICK ON

Eight envelopes, all looking the same from the outside. Only two of them hold anything.

SEALED BUNDLE 7302 The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19	SEALED BUNDLE 7320 The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19
SEALED BUNDLE 7323 The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19	SEALED BUNDLE 7324 The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19
SEALED BUNDLE FURROW The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19	SEALED BUNDLE HEIFER The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19
SEALED BUNDLE MANTLE The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19	SEALED BUNDLE PLEDGE The Chronicle Society · CASE JM-19

SLIPS FOR THE SIX EMPTY ENVELOPES

Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.	Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.
Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.	Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.
Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.	Not this one. Your working is wrong somewhere. Go back to the documents and check it line by line.

BUNDLE 7320

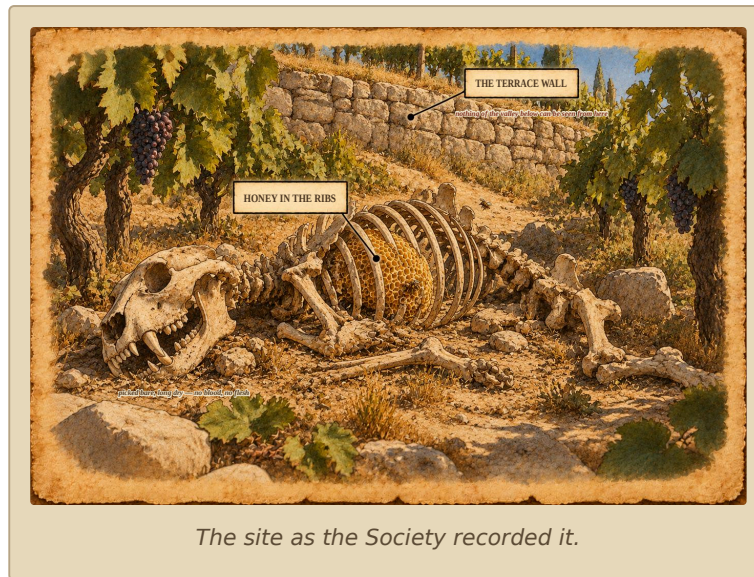
Bundle B — the site and the sums

Everything after this page and before the next sealed banner goes inside the envelope marked 7320.

DO NOT PUT THIS IN THE FOLDER

Report on the Carcass

Bundle B · the vineyard terrace



The Society examined the site and what was left of it.

FINDING	DETAIL
Location	Inside a terraced vineyard, above and away from the road
Condition when Samson returned	Dried out — enough time had passed for a swarm to settle in it
Occupants	A colony of bees and a comb of honey
Honey	Taken by hand. No tool marks, no jar, no second visitor
Other tracks at the site	None recorded
Reported to anyone at the time	No — no owner, no watchman, no complaint

WHY A STRANGER COULD NOT HAVE BUILT THE RIDDLE FROM THIS

Suppose a passing Philistine did climb up and find a dead lion full of bees. What would he have? A dead lion full of bees.

The riddle is not about a lion, and it is not about honey. **It is about a man taking food out of a killer he had beaten himself.** To turn this site into that riddle you would need to know who killed the lion, that he came back, and that he ate from it. None of that is lying on the ground.

Background: Judges 14:8–9.

ANALYSIS

Could the Riddle Be Reasoned Out?

Bundle B · the Society's assessment

WHAT A FAIR RIDDLE LOOKS LIKE

A fair riddle describes something everybody has access to — a door, a river, a shadow. Anyone patient enough can reach the answer, because the answer is in the world.

WHAT THIS ONE IS

"Out of the eater, something to eat. Out of the strong, something sweet." Read it cold, knowing nothing.

What is the eater? Any animal. Any person. Death itself. **What is the sweet thing?** Anything at all.

There is no chain of reasoning from those two lines to *a young lion Samson killed in a vineyard, and honey he later scraped out of its dried carcass with his hands*. That is not a deduction. That is a memory — and it is one man's memory.

WHAT THE PATTERN OF THE WEEK SHOWS

- Thirty men, three full days, no progress whatsoever.
- Nothing they did on days four, five or six moved them any closer.
- Then, on the last afternoon, a complete and exact answer.

Reasoning does not behave like that. Reasoning creeps. Being told arrives all at once.

If they had truly reasoned it out, the answer would have come to one of them slowly and been argued over. Instead it arrived finished.

Background: Judges 14:14, 14:17-18.

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RECORD

The Answer, As It Was Given

Bundle B · seventh day, before sundown

They did not walk up and say "a lion and some honey". They said this, and the record is careful to keep the wording:

"What is sweeter than honey?

What is stronger than a lion?"

THREE THINGS WORTH NOTICING ABOUT IT

- **It is in his own form.** Two lines, sweet and strong, in the same order he used. That is the shape of someone repeating something they have been handed, not the shape of someone who has just worked something out.
- **It is exact.** Not "a beast", not "some animal" — a lion. Not "something sweet" — honey.
- **It is late.** Delivered on the seventh day **before the sun went down:** as late as it could possibly be given, and still inside the terms.

An answer arrived at over seven days would have been offered the moment it was found. This one was held until the last hour — as if it had only just been received.

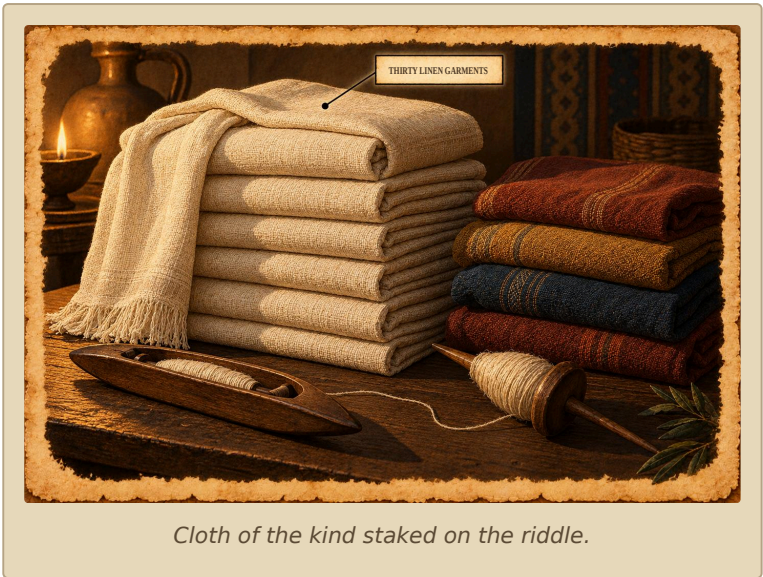
Background: Judges 14:18.

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VALUATION

What the Wager Was Worth

Bundle B · the motive



STAKE	AMOUNT
Linen garments	30
Changes of clothes	30
Men liable if they lost	30
Roughly, per man	one full outfit of good cloth — a serious expense for a young man of no property

INVESTIGATOR'S REMARK

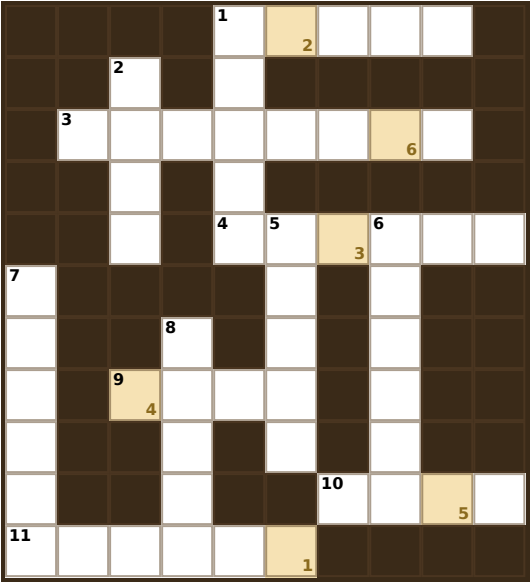
Cloth of this kind was not a trinket. It was woven by hand over weeks and it held its value like coin. Thirty young men who had cheerfully accepted a wager on the first day were, by the fourth, staring at a bill they had no way of meeting — **and at the humiliation of paying it to an Israelite in front of their own town.**

That is motive. It does not tell you what they did. It tells you how badly they needed to do something.

Background: Judges 14:12–13. Compare Judges 14:19, where Samson eventually settles the wager by force at Ashkelon.

THE RIDDLE SHEET

Every answer is a word you can find in the documents on your desk. Six squares carry a small number — collect those letters in number order and you have the keyword for the second lock.



ACROSS

- 1 How many days the feast was to last (5)
- 3 Where the young lion came roaring at Samson (8)
- 4 How many companions were brought to the feast (6)
- 9 What the thirty threatened Samson's wife with (4)
- 10 What had made a nest inside the dead lion (4)
- 11 The Philistine town where the wedding feast was held (6)

DOWN

- 1 'Out of the strong, something ____' (5)
- 2 What Samson killed with his bare hands (4)
- 5 What Samson scraped out of the carcass (5)
- 6 What Samson set before the thirty men (6)
- 7 The deadline on the seventh day (6)
- 8 The kind of garments staked in the wager (5)

THE NUMBERED SQUARES, IN ORDER

1

2

3

4

5

6

Enter the letters from the numbered squares in order to form the keyword for the second lock.

BUNDLE HEIFER

Sealed Bundle C — what was said in private

Everything after this page goes inside the envelope marked **HEIFER**.

DO NOT PUT THIS IN THE FOLDER

TESTIMONY

What the Thirty Said to Her

Sealed Bundle C · recorded afterwards by those who overheard

They did not offer her money. They did not reason with her. The record of what they put to her is short, and this is the whole of it:

RECORDED WORDS OF THE THIRTY

"Coax your husband into telling us the riddle, or we will burn you and your father's house with fire. Did you invite us here to make us poor?"

WHAT WAS ACTUALLY BEING SAID

- They went to her **privately**, away from Samson, on their own ground, where her family lived and his did not.
- They did not ask. **They threatened her home and her father's household.**
- And the threat was not an empty one. Not long afterwards, in the quarrel that followed all this, it was carried out.

This is the fact that reorders the whole case. She was not curious. She was frightened.

Background: Judges 14:15; the outcome referred to is Judges 15:6.

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STATEMENT

Statement — Samson's Wife*Sealed Bundle C · taken at Timnah*

"They came to me on my own. You already know what they said to me; I am not going to say it again.

My father's house is in this town. Their fathers' houses are in this town. Samson's is not.

So I went to him and I wept. I told him he hated me, that he did not love me, that he had put a riddle to my people and would not tell me the answer. **I wept in front of him for the rest of the feast**, because I did not know what else to do and because I could not tell him why.

On the last day he gave it to me. He was worn out with me. And I went straight out and told them, and I have not stopped thinking about the look on his face when they said it back to him.

You may write down that I told them. I did. **Write down as well what they said they would do to my family if I did not.**"

the wife of Samson

Background: Judges 14:16-17.

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FOLLOW-UP FILE

What Happened Afterwards

*Sealed Bundle C***IMMEDIATELY**

Samson paid the wager — by going down to Ashkelon and taking the cloth from thirty other Philistines by force. Then he went home to his father's house in a rage, and his wife was given to the companion who had been his best man.

THEN

He came back for her, found her married to someone else, and burned the Philistine grain fields. The Philistines answered by carrying out on her family exactly the threat the thirty had made in the first place. Samson answered that. And so on, and on.

WHY THE SOCIETY KEEPS THIS PAGE IN THE FILE

A wager about cloth turned into a feud that ran for years and cost a great many lives. Every step of it can be traced back to **one afternoon, one frightened person, and one secret that was worth more to somebody else than it was to the man who owned it.**

Nobody in this case set out to start a war. They set out to avoid paying for some clothes.

Background: Judges 14:19–20; 15:1–8.

✂ cut here

FIVE WAYS A SECRET TRAVELS

Only one man knew the answer, and the answer got out. Five routes have been offered. For each one, pin the single piece of evidence that closes it. When all five are closed, the accusation form opens.

1. Somebody followed him and saw it

A Philistine on the road watched Samson kill the lion, and later watched him take the honey.

GLUE THE EVIDENCE TAG HERE

2. His father and mother told them

They were on the road both times. Parents talk.

GLUE THE EVIDENCE TAG HERE

3. A traveller found the carcass and worked it out

Somebody stumbled on a dead lion full of bees and put two and two together.

GLUE THE EVIDENCE TAG HERE

4. The thirty solved it fairly

Thirty men, seven days, and a riddle is made to be solved.

GLUE THE EVIDENCE TAG HERE

5. Samson let it slip himself

Seven days of drinking with thirty companions. Sooner or later he talked.

GLUE THE EVIDENCE TAG HERE

EVIDENCE TAGS — CUT THESE OUT

One of these goes on each explanation. Some of them belong nowhere.

The Riddle and the Wager	Log of the Seven Days
Statement — Samson of Zorah	Statement — Samson's Father and Mother
The Road Down to Timnah	Statement — One of the Thirty
Report on the Carcass	Could the Riddle Be Reasoned Out?
The Answer, As It Was Given	What the Wager Was Worth
What the Thirty Said to Her	Statement — Samson's Wife
What Happened Afterwards	

ACCUSATION FORM — CASE JM-19

You have closed every route by which the answer could have reached the thirty by accident, observation or fair reasoning. It reached them anyway, on the last afternoon, in Samson's own words. Say plainly how.

- ☐ Somebody followed Samson and saw the lion and the honey.
- ☐ His father and mother passed the answer on.
- ☐ A traveller found the carcass and worked the riddle out from it.
- ☐ The thirty solved the riddle fairly, by reasoning.
- ☐ Samson let the answer slip himself during the drinking.
- ☐ The thirty threatened his wife with fire, she wept the answer out of Samson, and she carried it to them.

OUR REASONING

Name at least two pieces of evidence.

INVESTIGATORS

DATE



THE CHRONICLE SOCIETY · DEPARTMENT OF UNSOLVED ANTIQUITIES

Certificate of Investigation

This is to record that the case below was opened, worked and closed

INVESTIGATOR

CASE JM-19

The Broken Riddle

Timnah, Philistia · c. 1100 BC

Conclusion filed: The thirty threatened Samson's wife with fire; she wept the answer out of him and took it to them.

A. THORNE · CASE SUPERVISOR

TEACHER

DATE CLOSED

ANSWER KEY — CASE JM-19 · THE BROKEN RIDDLE

Locks. Lock 1 code 7320 (7 days of feast · 3 days of failure · 2 journeys to Timnah · 0 people told). Lock 2 keyword HEIFER, built on the Riddle Sheet crossword: the six numbered squares sit in TIMNAH, SEVEN, THIRTY, FIRE, BEES and VINEYARD.

Board. followed → The Road Down to Timnah; parents → Statement of the Father and Mother; stranger → Report on the Carcass; reasoned → Could the Riddle Be Reasoned Out?; slipped → Log of the Seven Days.

Conclusion. The thirty threatened Samson's wife with fire; she wept the answer out of him and took it to them.

If a team is stuck. "Who had something to lose in that week, and how much?" · "What changed on the seventh day?" · "Why does the wording of their answer matter?" · For the crossword: "every answer is in a document — which one would tell you this?"

Before you set this one. This case is heavier than the other two: the thirty threaten to burn the bride and her father's house, and Judges 15:6 records that it was later carried out. The file states this soberly and without detail, but it is worth knowing before you set it, and it makes the debrief question about pressure and power a real discussion rather than a comprehension exercise.

THE ELIMINATIONS IN FULL

1. Somebody followed him and saw it — The ground kills it. The vineyard terraces stand above the road and cannot be seen into from it — while anyone up in them can see the whole road. Samson left the path alone on both journeys and rejoined his parents afterwards. A witness would have had to leave the road, climb into a private vineyard, watch a man kill a lion bare-handed, come back months later to watch him eat honey out of it, and then say nothing to anybody until the seventh day of a wedding feast.

2. His father and mother told them — Their statement kills it. They were on the road, but they were not in the vineyard — and Samson told them nothing on either journey. He handed them honey and refused to say where it came from, and they assumed a hive in the rocks. They could not pass on an answer they did not have; they learned what the riddle meant on the seventh evening, from the shouting, along with everyone else.

3. A traveller found the carcass and worked it out — The field report kills it. A stranger finding that site has a dead lion full of bees — and nothing else. The riddle is not about a lion or about honey; it is about a man taking food out of a killer he had beaten himself. To build the riddle you would have to know who killed it, that he came back, and that he ate from it. None of that is lying on the ground, and no tracks, tools or reports place anyone else at the site.

4. The thirty solved it fairly — The analysis kills it. Read cold, 'the eater' could be any animal, any person, or death itself, and 'something sweet' could be anything at all — there is no chain of reasoning from those lines to one particular carcass in one particular vineyard. And the shape of the week gives it away: three days of nothing, then a complete, exact answer inside a single afternoon. Reasoning creeps. Being told arrives all at once.

5. Samson let it slip himself — The day log kills it. He sat with those thirty men for six days of open eating and drinking and the answer never came out of him. What changed on the seventh day was not the wine — it was that the weeping stopped. The answer surfaced within hours of his wife finally getting it out of him, and it came back to him in his own two-line form, exact and complete. He did not leak it to the room; he gave it to one person.

AFTERWARDS

- Samson called it betrayal. She said she was threatened with fire. Can both of those be true at the same time?

- The thirty never touched Samson. They went after the person with the least power in the room. Why is that so often how pressure works?
- Samson kept the lion secret even from his parents, then gave it away in a week to someone he had known barely longer. What does the case suggest about him?
- A wager about clothes ended in years of killing. At which single point in the week could somebody have stopped it — and what would that have cost them?

Judges 14 (the whole chapter) · Judges 15:1–8 · Judges 13:1–5 for the background